[Working Draft] Village Forestry Models - Mitsue vs Nishiawakura, Tenkawa, Kurotaki, Shimokawa

A work in progress, updated as we get a clearer picture of how things are set up. Content changes often

v1.2 · 2026-10-28 · Working draft · Based on public sources and interviews

Working draft: everything here is in flux and will change as we learn more. **Nothing is secured yet.** Mitsue column = current understanding (navy), a draft for discussion; confidence for all peers is partial except Shimokawa (verified).

	Mitsue 御杖村 (current understanding)	Nishiawakura 西粟倉村	Tenkawa 天川村	Kurotaki 黒滝村	Shimokawa 下川町
Prefecture	Nara	Okayama	Nara	Nara	Hokkaido
Population	~1,500 (unverified)	~1,500	n/a	~650	~3,000
Forest share	~90%+ (unverified)	95% of 57.93 km²	97% of 175.66 km²	97% (92% of forest is plantation)	88%
Who pools owners	No owner group found. Owners deal individually; coop acts as the owners' body; 森林経営管理 owner-survey data not yet obtained (to confirm with the village hall).	Village itself: owners sign long-term management-entrustment contracts (百年の森林事業).	洞川財産区 (collective property district) for part of the forest; village forest; 3-party council (フォレストパワー協議会: village + coop + chamber).	Not documented in sources read (森林経営管理 route not confirmed).	Town buys forest rather than pooling private owners: national forest 1,221 ha in 1953 (¥88M), +1,902 ha in 1994-2003. Coop has 271 members (2024).
Village role	Village hall (産業建設課) takes 伐採届; thinning is done owner by owner (no central coordination mechanism found). Ordinance lets village loan forestry machinery (ex-協力隊). Funded biomass once (FY2018), not continued. Neglected-forest programme (施業放置林整備事業) covers ~2,600 ha. Council has stated that crew and machinery capacity is the bottleneck (2020) and a policy of using thinned wood at tourism facilities (2021).	Contractor and re-delegator (施業受託者兼再委任者); runs special account (特別会計); FSC group certification; local-venture support (エーゼロ).	Convener and funder; owns/manages village forest; buys logs from residents for vouchers.	Plans and manages the 担い手 programme with the coop: recruits outside forestry workers (housing + training support); seeks 企業版ふるさと納税; Yoshino forestry birthplace.	Owner and planner: town forest ~4,500-4,600 ha on a 60-year rotation (~50 ha/yr cut and replant); FSC certified 2003 (first in Hokkaido); runs heat network; town + coop are the implementing bodies.
Coop role	Coop supplies wood to the onsen (likely A/B grade now, not CHP heat); owners' body.	Executes the work (美作東備森林組合): harvesting and forest crews.	Council member; named forestry body.	黒滝村森林組合: partner in recruiting and training outside workers; sends technicians to Switzerland; builds 特殊伐採 skills, which raised outside-area management requests.	下川町森林組合: does the forestry work on town forest; ~18,000 m3/yr, FY2024 business volume ¥480M; wood charcoal start 1981; also FSC certified.
Private operators	Independent operators; owners pick operators individually (owner-initiated). Reportedly 10+ active, large and small.	Local ventures downstream (processing, heat, media); forestry operators work under the coop.	New local operators via 協力隊 and a youth LLP (2024).	Not documented (no private-operator split found).	Existing fuel dealers form エネルギー供給協同組合 to supply chips; local sawmills and laminated-wood makers (e.g. Shimokawa Forest Family) downstream.
Machinery	Village machinery-loan ordinance; shared harvester idea under discussion.	Village leases forestry machinery to coop; rental income flows to village account.	Not documented.	Not documented.	Not documented.
Wood use / heat	Onsen gets coop wood; 牛峠工場 chips/dries; small CHP (~50 kWe) prototype under consideration, site not decided; FIT premium ¥32 vs ¥24 if 森林経営計画. Good-grade logs mostly sold outside the village (e.g. Misugi market, Sakurai timber coop).	A/B grade to 西粟倉・森の学校 processing; C grade to heat company 村楽エナジー (firewood, heat to onsen and public buildings).	4 wood-boiler facilities (onsen, nursing home, visitor centre); log-for-voucher loop.	Woodworking group スギイロ (Apr 2021): 3 coop employees + 1 協力隊 coordinator, traditional 水組木工 / 透かし彫り crafts; forest-experience guides.	Wood boilers since 2004 (五味温泉 180 kW) now ~60% of public-facility heating; district heat networks; logs to local sawmills; wood interiors in public buildings.
Money	¥0 committed as of 2026-07-11; pipeline only (EVM plan). No village budget line found for replanting (thinning only).	Village account; 共有の森ファンド (with トビムシ); since 2020 forest-trust scheme with Sumitomo Forestry and Sumitomo Mitsui Trust Bank.	みらい基金 grant; more trees corporate sponsors (agreement 2021-06-07); J-Credit; 森林環境税.	企業版ふるさと納税; 農山漁村振興交付金 (山村活性化) from FY2019 for crafts succession.	Town budget (forest income as base fund); 環境未来都市 / SDGs model funding; GPP CO2 subsidies (e.g. ¥17.0M of ¥33.3M).
Relevance to Mitsue	**Baseline for comparison. Differences from peers (as far as confirmed): no pooling body, village-led contracting or special account found.**	**Nearest match to the polder idea; machine-rental fits shared harvester; needs the village hall to lead.**	**Same prefecture; more trees partner; shows property-district route to one agreement for a whole area.**	**Same prefecture, Yoshino region, depopulation + successor shortage; coop-led workforce model and Swiss training mirror Nara forester idea.**	**Best-documented small-town chain forest-to-heat; key idea: town owns the resource base and uses existing fuel dealers rather than replacing them (relevant to Mitsue operator politics).**
Confidence	partial	partial	partial	partial	verified
Open gaps / notes	Model as of 2026-10-09; update as stakeholders confirm.	Start year (believed 2008), area, owner count, contract length not confirmed.	Not found: who executes work, contractor selection, any coop-vs-private conflict.	Need: who owns/harvests village forest, coop member count, private operators, machinery.	Coop size differs by source and year (12 workers older MAFF case vs ~64 people in a later summary).

Sources: Internal research notes; Nishiawakura: https://www.chisou.go.jp/tiiki/kankyo/miraitoshi/itiran/pdf/nishiawakura.pdf ; http://future-city.go.jp/doc/pdf/torikumi_city/nishiawakura_panel.pdf; Tenkawa: Village brochure 2025/09; vill.tenkawa.nara.jp/office/administration/farm/forestry; Kurotaki: https://www.chisou.go.jp/tiiki/tiikisaisei/portal/pdf/dai25/207kurotakimura.pdf (read); pref.nara.jp kurotaki.pdf (403, not read); Shimokawa: https://www.env.go.jp/policy/local_keikaku/pdf/2_01_shimokawa.pdf ; https://www.hokkaido-np.co.jp/article/1172805/ ; https://japan.iclei.org/en/member-list/member_shimokawa/